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Emhoff at Jewish California Summit; Israel's Birthday; New AFTAU Hire; Repair the World

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Former Second Gentleman of the U.S. Doug Emhoff — the first Jewish spouse of a U.S. Vice President — recently shared how proud he is of being Jewish.

"I love being Jewish and I'm proud of being Jewish," he said. "It's still true and it will always be true. I think we need to feel that joy and that spirit, just that love of our culture and each other and embrace that... that's my message."

Emhoff made these comments as one of dozens of speakers at this year's Jewish California Capitol Summit, held May 11-12 at the Sheraton Grand Hotel in Sacramento, where he was tasked with speaking about legislative and legal efforts to fight antisemitism, particularly on the state level.

He was appearing in conversation with State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) as well as attorney Alex Weingarten.

The 700 audience members in the hotel ballroom were perhaps most curious about whether Emhoff's wife, former Vice President Kamala Harris, would be running again for the presidency in 2028, and Gabriel asked him straight out if this was a possibility. On this, Emhoff was intentionally vague. "She's thinking about it — she's thinking seriously about it," Emhoff said.

Asked if he would ever consider running for office, he surprised some in the crowd when he said, "Maybe one day down the line I'll throw my hat into something."

Emhoff, among other topics, discussed how troubled he's been by the rise of antisemitism. He denounced the recent attack at a synagogue in West Bloomfield, Michigan. "These kids are just trying to go to school and there was an attempt to harm them," he said.

He also spoke about the efforts of the Biden-Harris administration to tackle Jew-hatred strategically and how much worse the problem has gotten in recent years.

Post-Oct. 7, he said, "we went from a problem of antisemitism to a crisis of antisemitism."

Additional speakers at the two-day summit organized by Jewish California — formerly known as the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California—included L.A. County District Attorney Nathan Hochman, Jewish California CEO David Bocarsly, Assemblymember Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Hollywood) and California Lieutenant Governor Eleni Kounalakis.

On April 21, more than 600 people gathered at the Eretz Cultural Center in Tarzana to celebrate Israel's Independence Day. Temple Ramat Zion Rabbi Ahud Sela, president of the Board of Rabbis of Southern California; Temple Judea Rabbi Cantor Alison Wissot; Zev Hurwitz, director of synagogue and rabbinic outreach at the Jewish Federation Los Angeles, and Rebecca Aghalarpour, executive director of the Eretz Cultural Center, organized the evening of song, dance and celebration. Cantors and choirs from synagogues across the San Fernando Valley were featured along with the Keshet Chaim Dance Ensemble; ShinShinim; and Mia Mizrachi from de Toledo High School. Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles Israel Bachar and rabbis from across the San Fernando Valley were featured speakers.

American Friends of Tel Aviv University (AFTAU) CEO Ben Pery has named Shelly Medved to the newly created role of integrated Chief Operating Officer and Chief Financial Officer.

Medved is a San Fernando Valley local. She brings over 14 years of nonprofit leadership experience and, as a Tel Aviv University MBA alumna, has a deep personal connection to the organization's mission. She will be based out of AFTAU's Los Angeles office.

Repair the World Los Angeles recently partnered with Exodus Leadership, Pastor Michael JT Fisher, Stephen Wise Temple Rabbi Yoshi Zweiback, Zioness Movement, Greater Zion Church Family and the Black Jewish Entertainment Alliance for a day of service and connection in Compton. The April 26 gathering brought neighbors together across lines of difference, with more than 100 volunteers standing

side-by-side to make a meaningful impact in the community.

Through hands-on service, volunteers of all ages and backgrounds fostered meaningful connections. The joy of shared laughter, stories and impact was palpable throughout the day. This was the latest in a series of collaborative bridge-building service and learning opportunities that embody the organizations' shared commitment to mutual service and solidarity. They are expected to partner again for the next volunteer opportunity in June, reconnecting in Pico-Robertson to make meals for those experiencing hardship.

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